



DRAFT — FOR SARAH'S REVIEW

Employee Handbook

OptiMind Educational Strategies — prepared by Ruby Groves, Gemini Lane

Applies to · All OptiMind employees **Status** · Draft **Last updated** · Aug 16, 2026

Not legal advice. A handbook carries real legal weight — the PTO/sick-leave section in particular needs to be checked against Maryland's paid sick and safe leave requirements before this is issued, and the whole document should get an attorney's pass alongside the Employment Agreement.

1. Welcome

OptiMind Educational Strategies provides executive-function coaching and educational advocacy for middle and high school, college, and adult clients, founded and led by Sarah Ritter. This handbook covers what to expect day to day — pair it with the Role Definition & Responsibilities and Client Workflow documents, which cover the job itself.

2. Employment Basics

- Employment is at-will and W-2, per the Employment Agreement.
- You report to Sarah Ritter, Founder.
- A weekly one-to-one is part of the regular schedule from week one.

3. Work Schedule & Availability

Expected working days and hours: 9am–7pm ET Monday–Thursday, 9am–4pm ET Friday.

4. Time Off

Two different things live under "time off" — leave Maryland requires the practice to offer, and vacation/holiday time that's entirely Sarah's call. Splitting them out so it's clear which parts are negotiable.

SICK & SAFE LEAVE (MARYLAND-MANDATED MINIMUM)

Under Maryland's Healthy Working Families Act, employees who work at least 12 hours a week accrue sick and safe leave — usable for the employee's own illness, a family member's illness, or safe leave related to domestic violence or a similar situation.

- Accrues at 1 hour for every 30 hours worked, up to 40 hours per year — or Sarah can front-load the full 40 hours at the start of the year instead of tracking accrual.
- Because OptiMind has fewer than 15 employees, this leave is required to be **unpaid** under state law — Sarah can choose to pay it as a benefit, but isn't required to.
- Employees become eligible to use accrued leave after their first 106 calendar days of employment.
- Up to 40 unused hours carry over to the next year; usage can be capped at 64 hours in a single year.

Confirm before this is final — these are the general Healthy Working Families Act rules as commonly summarized; verify current thresholds and requirements directly (Maryland DOL) or with an employment attorney before treating this as policy, especially since the employee count that triggers different rules matters here.

VACATION & PERSONAL DAYS (DISCRETIONARY — SARAH'S CALL)

Proposed, not decided — no Maryland or federal law requires paid vacation. As a starting point for discussion: **TBD** — e.g., a set number of paid days per year, accruing from the start date or granted at hire.

PAID HOLIDAYS (DISCRETIONARY — SARAH'S CALL)

TBD — which holidays the practice observes as paid days off. Common default is the standard federal holidays, but this is entirely optional and should match how the practice actually operates around school breaks and terms.

REQUESTING TIME OFF

Per the New Hire Decision List, time-off approval stays with Sarah. **TBD** — how much advance notice is expected for a planned absence, and who covers the caseload while the specialist is out.

5. Code of Conduct

- Professional conduct with clients, families, and outside providers at all times.
- Appropriate boundaries with minor clients, consistent with the practice's existing standards.

DRESS CODE

Business casual: neat and professional, appropriate for meeting with parents, schools, and other providers over video. All sessions are currently virtual — there is no in-person policy at this time.

- Video sessions: camera-ready, business casual, professional/uncluttered background.
- Camera is positioned with the specialist backed up against a wall — no window, hallway, or open room visible behind them — so the background is free of distractions and there's no chance of someone walking through the shot mid-session.

6. Communication Norms

Splits into two different things: how the specialist and Sarah communicate day to day, and how the specialist communicates with clients and families.

INTERNAL (SPECIALIST & SARAH)

Proposed, not decided — email for anything that benefits from a written record; text or call for same-day scheduling logistics. The weekly one-to-one is the standing venue for anything that isn't urgent.

Confirm — is there a shared tool beyond email/text (e.g., a shared calendar or Slack), or does everything run through personal email and phone today?

OPERATIONAL & SOP QUESTIONS

If a question comes up about how to handle something — and it isn't clearly answered in this handbook or the other SOP documents — email Sarah directly with the question and **CC Ruby Groves** (ruby.groves@gemini-lane.com). Sarah answers directly, same as any other question; the CC is just how a documentation gap gets tracked and closed instead of staying a one-off answer.

CLIENT-FACING COMMUNICATION

- All client interactions — email, text, and phone calls — go through OptiMind's company email and company phone number only. Personal email and personal phone numbers are never used for client communication, with no exceptions. Full policy in Section 10 (Technology & Equipment).
- Expected response time for client-facing messages: **proposed — same business day, confirm with Sarah**.

URGENT & SAFETY MATTERS

Anything covered under Section 10 (Safety & Escalation) bypasses normal response-time expectations entirely — call Sarah directly rather than waiting for the next scheduled check-in.

7. Client Confidentiality & Data Handling

Governed by the separate Confidentiality & Data-Handling Agreement, signed at hire — not duplicated here. Every employee is bound by it for the duration of employment and after.

8. Session & Documentation Standards

Session notes, curriculum coverage tracking, and goals-tracker entries follow the Client Workflow — Intake to Graduation document. Notes are logged immediately after each session — not batched for later.

9. Identifying Advocacy & College Counseling Needs

TBD — not yet a finished protocol. This section is a placeholder, not a working procedure. We need a way to ask relevant questions during EF sessions that surfaces whether a client actually needs Special Education Advocacy or College Counseling — the other two service lines in the Services Agreement — and what the specialist does once that need is identified. Until this is built out, treat it as a flag that this gap exists, not a process to follow.

SPOTTING THE NEED

TBD — what are the actual signals during an EF coaching session that point to an unmet advocacy or college-counseling need (e.g. an upcoming IEP/504 meeting, a school dispute, application-season timelines)? This needs a concrete set of questions or prompts the specialist can use in-session, not a vague instinct call.

WHAT THE SPECIALIST DOES

Advocacy and College Counseling work is handled by **Sarah**, not the EF specialist — consistent with the Role Definition & Responsibilities document's "what stays with Sarah" list. The specialist's job here is to **identify and flag**, not to perform the advocacy or college-counseling work itself.

- When a need is identified, the specialist tells the client (and parent/guardian, if the client is a minor) that this looks like advocacy or college-counseling territory, and that it's handled separately from the regular EF sessions.
- The client and Sarah are both made aware that **additional, dedicated sessions** are needed to map out that work — it doesn't get folded into the existing EF session time.
- The specialist notifies Sarah of the flag **TBD — confirm the channel and turnaround: same-week one-to-one, or something faster?**
- The flag and how it was handled get documented in the client file, per Section 8 (Session & Documentation Standards).

10. Safety & Escalation

Interim skeleton only — not a finished protocol. This is a starting structure, not clinical or legal guidance. Before this section is real policy, it needs Sarah's actual answer, and ideally a pass from a licensed mental-health consultant and an attorney on Maryland's mandated-reporter rules — those determine real obligations here, and depend on specifics (licensure, role) this draft can't responsibly guess at. Until it's confirmed, treat every step below as a proposal, not a rule to follow in a real moment.

IF THERE'S IMMEDIATE DANGER

Proposed — active suicidal intent with a plan or means, or active self-harm in progress: don't leave the client alone (in person) or end the call (virtual). Call 911 or direct the client to emergency care. For a minor, the parent/guardian is contacted immediately alongside emergency services. Sarah is called as soon as the immediate danger is addressed, not before.

IF THERE'S A DISCLOSURE, BUT NOT IMMEDIATE DANGER

Proposed — passive ideation or a safety concern without immediate risk: don't promise confidentiality on this topic going in. Gather what's needed gently, without trying to make a clinical risk determination alone. Contact Sarah the same day — this doesn't wait for the next scheduled check-in.

MANDATED REPORTING

TBD — needs an attorney's answer, not a guess. Whether the specialist qualifies as a mandated reporter under Maryland law for suspected child abuse or neglect depends on licensure and role, which hasn't been confirmed. This determines real legal obligations and shouldn't be assumed either way.

DOCUMENTATION

Whatever was disclosed and how it was handled gets documented factually and promptly, consistent with the Data-Handling Policy.

AFTER

Debrief with Sarah in the next weekly one-to-one, or sooner if the situation calls for it.

11. Technology & Equipment

What the specialist works with day to day, and where the lines are on personal devices.

COMPANY EMAIL & PHONE (CLIENT INTERACTIONS)

Every client-facing interaction — email, text message, and phone call — happens through OptiMind's company email address and company phone number, never a personal account or personal number. This applies to all contact with clients, parents/guardians, and any client-related correspondence with schools or outside providers.

- Company email: **TBD — provisioned before day one per the Week-One Onboarding Schedule; confirm the specialist's official OptiMind address here once assigned.**
- Company phone number: **TBD — a dedicated business line is needed for calls and texts with clients; confirm whether this is a company-issued phone, a forwarding number, or a VoIP line before day one.**
- Personal email and personal phone numbers are never used for client interactions, with no exceptions — this keeps a clean boundary and a complete record of what was said, per Section 6.
- Session video backgrounds follow the Dress Code standard in Section 5 — camera backed up to a wall, no distractions, no chance of someone walking through the shot.

DEVICES

TBD — company-issued devices vs. personal devices for client-related work. Same open question as the Confidentiality & Data-Handling Agreement; whatever gets decided there governs here too, not duplicated.

ACCOUNTS & SOFTWARE ACCESS

Provisioned before day one, per the Week-One Onboarding Schedule: email, calendar, and access to the current tool set — Calendly and Zoom for scheduling, PandaDoc for agreements, and the client file storage location. The session-notetaking tool and the practice-management platform are both still pending roadmap decisions (Sprint 02 and Sprint 03), so this list will grow once those land.

PERSONAL DEVICE & DATA HANDLING

Governed by the Confidentiality & Data-Handling Agreement and the Data-Handling Policy — not duplicated here. Whatever is or isn't allowed on a personal device follows those documents directly.

EQUIPMENT RETURN

Per the Employment Agreement: any company-issued devices, materials, and system access are returned or revoked upon termination.

12. Performance & Growth

How the specialist knows how they're doing, both week to week and over the longer run.

PROBATIONARY PERIOD

Proposed, not decided — a 90-day initial period, roughly aligned with reaching the steady-state caseload target in the Week-One Onboarding Schedule, is a reasonable starting point. **Confirm the length, and what (if anything) changes once it ends.**

ONGOING CHECK-INS

The weekly one-to-one is the standing rhythm for performance conversations — not a separate review process layered on top.

FORMAL REVIEWS

TBD — no formal review cadence is set yet. A review at the end of the probationary period, then **annually or semi-annually — confirm**, is a reasonable structure to propose.

GROWTH & PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

TBD — whether OptiMind supports continuing education, certifications, or conference attendance hasn't been discussed yet.

13. Termination

Per the Employment Agreement: at-will, with property and system access returned per that agreement's terms.

14. Equal Employment Opportunity

Draft language — confirm with an attorney before treating as final. Standard EEO boilerplate, adapted for Maryland; the exact protected-class list and any employer-size caveats should get an attorney's sign-off rather than resting on this draft alone.

POLICY STATEMENT

OptiMind Educational Strategies is committed to equal employment opportunity. Employment decisions — including hiring, compensation, promotion, discipline, and termination — are made without regard to race, color, religion, sex, sexual orientation, gender identity, national origin, age, disability, genetic information, marital status, or any other status protected by federal, Maryland, or local law.

A NOTE ON EMPLOYER SIZE

Confirm with an attorney — several federal EEO laws (including Title VII and the ADA) only apply once an employer reaches a minimum employee count, and Maryland's own Fair Employment Practices Act has its own thresholds and exceptions. At one employee, OptiMind may not yet be legally required to comply with every federal provision — but adopting the policy now, ahead of when it's required, is generally good practice rather than something to decide by default.

By signing below, I acknowledge that I have received and read the OptiMind Employee Handbook.

Employee signature & date

Sarah Ritter, Founder & date

Open Questions for Sarah

1. Does the interim protocol in Section 10 match how you'd actually want this handled, or does it need to change before anyone relies on it? (highest priority — same flag as the Employee Reference Sheet and Decision List)

2. What are the actual signals/questions that should prompt a specialist to flag an advocacy or college-counseling need during an EF session (Section 9)?
3. How should the specialist notify you once a need is flagged — same-week one-to-one, or something faster?
4. Is the specialist a mandated reporter under Maryland law given their specific licensure/role — this needs an attorney's answer, not an assumption either way.
5. Has this protocol been reviewed by a licensed mental-health consultant, or should one be brought in before it's finalized?
6. Should sick and safe leave be paid as a benefit, even though it's only legally required to be unpaid at this size?
7. How many paid vacation days per year, if any?
8. Which holidays does the practice observe as paid days off?
9. How much advance notice is expected for a planned absence, and who covers the caseload while the specialist is out?
10. Is 90 days the right length for the probationary period, and does anything change once it ends?
11. What's the formal review cadence after that — annual, semi-annual, something else?
12. Does OptiMind support continuing education, certifications, or conference attendance?
13. Is there a shared internal communication tool beyond email/text, or does everything run through personal email and phone today?
14. Is same-business-day the right response-time expectation for client-facing messages?
15. Company-issued devices, or is personal-device use allowed for client work? (same answer settles this section, the Confidentiality Agreement, and the Data-Handling Policy at once)
16. What is the specialist's company email address and company phone number/line, so Section 10 can point to the real ones instead of TBD?
17. Has an attorney reviewed the EEO statement and confirmed which federal/Maryland provisions actually apply at OptiMind's current size?